

01

CONCEPTUAL METHOD: WHAT PROBLEM IS BEING ASKED?

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A high-scoring answer states which burden is being met.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The availability of a second-order good does not by itself show that the first-order evil was necessary or proportionate.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Evil can rebut or undercut a proof, but this session does not repeat the proofs.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

A modal defence can answer the first while leaving the other three largely untouched.

ANSWER LINE: The problem of evil is not one argument but a family of challenges generated by the relation among a divine profile, the facts of suffering and wrongdoing, and norms governing what a good agent would permit.

02

CLASSICAL FORMULATION AND MACKIE'S LOGICAL PROBLEM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

[REPLY] Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The dilemma is transmitted in later discussion, prominently through Lactantius, and Hume's Dialogues Concerning Natural Religion gives a celebrated modern formulation through Philo.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The logical debate therefore turns on whether those bridging premises are unrestricted.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

[REPLY] Logical possibility is not an ad hoc restriction invented for evil; it is part of the standard concept of power.

ANSWER LINE: The familiar questions - whether God is willing but unable, able but unwilling, or both able and willing while evil exists - are commonly labelled the Epicurean paradox.

03

PLANTINGA'S FREE WILL DEFENCE

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

A person is significantly free with respect to an action when the action is morally significant and the person is free to perform or refrain from it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Alvin Plantinga's Free Will Defence aims at the logical problem.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

If God causally determines every significantly free choice to be right, the choice is not libertarianly free in relation to God.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

[OBJECTION] Why could God not create free persons who always freely choose the good, as the blessed might in heaven?

ANSWER LINE: The defence is strongest for moral evil.

04

EVIDENTIAL EVIL: ROWE, PROBABILITY AND SKEPTICAL THEISM

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Skeptical theists challenge our entitlement to infer from "no reason we can see" to "probably no reason." Wykstra's CORNEA-style principle asks whether, if the proposed good existed, it is reasonable to expect that we would discern it.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

We should prevent suffering because we lack authority to assume an unknown justifying plan.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

The point is comparative likelihood, not a numerical probability assignment.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

The case is illustrative, not a claim that one event alone deductively disproves God.

ANSWER LINE: Evidential force depends on a noseum move: "We see no justifying reason; therefore there probably is none." Such reasoning is strong when observers would likely detect the relevant reason if it existed, as when looking for an elephant in a small room.

05

CLASSICAL THEODICIES AND DEFENCES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Irenaeus supplies the image-to-likeness developmental theology; John Keats supplies the phrase 'vale of soul-making'; Hick develops the modern theodicy.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Augustine treats evil as a privation of good arising through created freedom, not as a positive substance created by God.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Likewise, a will is good as a created capacity but becomes evil by disordered attachment to a lesser good over the highest good.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

[QUALIFICATION] What it preserves or explains: It addresses moral and natural evil within one developmental framework and explains why God is not overwhelmingly evident.

ANSWER LINE: Created being is good insofar as it has being; evil is not a positive substance made by God but a privation, corruption or disorder of a due good.

06

NON-CLASSICAL THEISMS AND REVISED DIVINE ATTRIBUTES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

The operative mechanism is that open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God...

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Divine action is persuasive rather than coercive, not merely because God voluntarily self-limits but because unilateral control is metaphysically unavailable.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

God is not the author of evil and receives the world's suffering in divine experience.

ANSWER LINE: Open theism holds that future free acts are genuinely open and known by God as possibilities rather than settled facts.

07

EXISTENTIAL EVIL, PROTEST AND HORRENDOUS EVILS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

The force is moral protest: even if an explanation exists, may one accept its price?

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

[THESIS] Horrendous evils are participation in which gives a person prima facie reason to doubt whether their life can be a great good to them.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

They are not substitutes for formal argument; they test its existential and ethical adequacy.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

[REPLY] A restrained defence may claim only that God and evil are not contradictory, while refusing to specify the purpose of each atrocity.

ANSWER LINE: Existential approaches ask not only whether a proposition is coherent but what stance is humanly and morally possible before suffering.

08

INDIAN AND NON-WESTERN FRAMEWORKS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

[THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma (morally consequential action) and liberation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

[THESIS] Indian traditions do not share one answer because they disagree about creator, self, world, karma and liberation.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Nyaya (school of logic and realism): Ishvara (Lord or personal God) can administer unseen karmic potency and cosmic order; God is not an arbitrary author but a just allocator.

ANSWER LINE: Indian And Non-Western Frameworks comprises Indian, Non-Western Frameworks and Nyaya as its core connected dimensions.

09

HARD CASES AND META-LEVEL CRITIQUES

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Technically, Hard Cases And Meta-Level Critiques is analysed by relating Hard Cases to Meta-Level Critiques, then testing the relationship through Major criticism and Animal suffering.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

[OBJECTION] Theodicy can legitimate the status quo by redescribing oppression as discipline, karma (morally consequential action) or providence.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Each proposal carries speculative commitments and must not treat animals merely as instruments for human virtues.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Stable-law and evolutionary accounts explain mechanisms and goods such as complex life, but not obviously the intensity and duration of sentient pain.

ANSWER LINE: Animal suffering is a central evidential challenge because predation, disease, parasitism and extinction precede human agency and often seem unrelated to moral growth.

10

COMPARATIVE SYNTHESIS AND PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Theodicies should be compared through the divine attribute revised, the evil explained, the residual case and the moral cost of the explanation.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Protest: need not be unbelief; Job-like protest can occur within a relationship.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Agents must prevent avoidable suffering because they are not entitled to assume it is necessary.

ANSWER LINE: Final verdict: Comparison is strongest when each position is judged through the same axes of ultimate reality, world relation, human relation, causation and religious function.